The Quiet Category: Why So Many of Us Are Spiritual Without the Membership Card

An inquiry into omnism, the spiritual-but-not-religious, and the numbers that suggest you may already be in the room.

By Claudia G. Petersen

It started with a description. Someone laid out a position that was neither atheist nor conventionally religious: a measured interest in older Jewish texts and newer finds, a selective appreciation for Vedic, Zen, and Daoist material where the ideas overlapped, an openness to the possibility of a creator or a simulation without any requirement that it be benign, and a refusal to treat any of it as binding dogma. No prayers. No ladder of good deeds leading to a reward. Just the sense that existence has some reason, even if the reason remains unclaimed.

The label that fits most cleanly is **omnist**—someone who holds that no single tradition has a monopoly on truth, and that partial insights can be drawn from several without requiring exclusive commitment. In the surveys that actually count people, the closest measurable category is the one Pew Research Center has been tracking as **spiritual but not religious** (SBNR). In the United States in 2023, that group is 22 percent of adults.

If you are reading this and the description above felt familiar rather than exotic, you are probably already in or adjacent to that 22 percent. The rest of this piece is an attempt to show where the numbers place that stance relative to everyone else, and what the data look like once the conversation moves past the label itself.

What People in This Category Actually Do

Omnism itself is primarily a stance rather than a liturgy. There is no required practice, which is part of the appeal. What shows up consistently among people who describe themselves this way is comparatively light and non-exclusive: comparative reading across traditions, some form of non-religious meditation or mindfulness, occasional symbolic acts that mark a season or a loss, a strong emphasis on non-harm and intellectual honesty, and the occasional respectful attendance at a service or teaching from a tradition they do not formally join. None of this is treated as a ladder that improves one’s standing with an external judge.

That pattern matches the broader SBNR profile. Pew finds that 58 percent of SBNRs regularly spend time looking inward to connect with their “true self,” with something bigger than themselves, or with other people. They are more likely than religious Americans to spend time in nature specifically for connection. They are also more likely to own crystals for spiritual purposes—an object-level practice that does not require institutional affiliation.

How Common Is This, and Where?

Direct counts of self-identified omnists do not exist; the category is too small and too loosely bounded for most surveys. SBNR and the broader religiously unaffiliated (“nones”) are the usable proxies. In the United States, the 22 percent SBNR figure sits alongside 58 percent who are religious (of whom 48 percent are both religious and spiritual) and 21 percent who are neither. Globally, the religiously unaffiliated share of the population rose from 23 percent in 2010 to 24 percent in 2020, according to Pew’s multi-country estimates. The absolute number grew by roughly 270 million people over that decade.

The growth has been uneven. North America saw the largest percentage-point increase in the unaffiliated share. Europe also rose. In many European countries and in East Asia, the unaffiliated already form a large plurality or majority. The practical consequence is that a reader in London, New York, or Seoul is statistically more likely to be sitting next to someone with an SBNR-adjacent outlook than a reader in a high-religiosity region of sub-Saharan Africa or the Middle East.

Category (Pew 2023, U.S. adults)	Share
Spiritual but not religious (SBNR)	22%
Religious and spiritual	48%
Religious but not spiritual	10%
Neither spiritual nor religious	21%

U.S. adult self-description, Pew Research Center, 2023. SBNR is defined by affirmative answers on spirituality combined with negative or non-affirmative answers on religion.

What Happens After Death, According to the Numbers

SBNRs are not uniformly skeptical of continuation after death, nor are they uniformly traditional. Pew’s 2023 data show that 89 percent of SBNRs believe people have a soul or spirit in addition to a physical body—statistically indistinguishable from the religious-and-spiritual group. Belief in a conventional heaven drops to 54 percent, and belief in hell to 40 percent. Only 38 percent affirm both. Reincarnation, by contrast, is affirmed by 43 percent of SBNRs as definitely or probably true, higher than among religious Americans (24 percent).

The pattern is one of selective retention: high acceptance of a non-material component to a person, lower acceptance of the traditional dual destination, and elevated openness to some form of return or continuation that does not require a final judgment.

Belief (SBNR, Pew 2023)	Share
People have a soul or spirit	89%
Heaven	54%
Hell	40%
Both heaven and hell	38%

Reincarnation (definitely or probably true)	43%

Selected afterlife-related beliefs among U.S. adults classified as spiritual but not religious. Source: Pew Research Center, 2023.

Spirits, Energies, and the Less Corporeal

The same survey shows a clear tilt toward distributed spiritual presence. Seventy-two percent of SBNRs believe that spirits or unseen spiritual forces exist (nearly identical to the religious group). The distinctive feature is location: 78 percent say animals other than humans can have spirits or spiritual energies; 71 percent say the same of parts of nature such as mountains, rivers, or trees; 42 percent extend the idea to objects such as crystals, jewels, or stones. Seventy-three percent affirm “some other higher power or spiritual force in the universe” rather than the God described in the Bible.

Experiential claims are also elevated. Forty-eight percent of SBNRs report having had a strong feeling that someone who has passed away was communicating with them from beyond this world—higher than both religious Americans (41 percent) and those who are neither spiritual nor religious (21 percent). Fifty-five percent report a sudden feeling of connection with something from beyond this world.

Belief that ancestral spirits can actively help or harm the living is lower and more variable. In most countries surveyed by Pew, between 20 and 40 percent of religiously unaffiliated adults hold this view. The U.S. figure for the general population is 36 percent. The SBNR subset is not broken out separately, but the higher rate of reported communication experiences suggests that a substantial minority within the group treat some form of ongoing contact as possible, even if active ancestral intervention is not the dominant view.

Belief or experience (SBNR)	Share
Spirits or unseen spiritual forces exist	72%
Spirits/energies in animals	78%
Spirits/energies in nature (mountains, rivers, trees)	71%
Spirits/energies in objects (crystals, etc.)	42%
Other higher power (not biblical God)	73%
Felt communication from someone who has died	48%
Sudden connection with something beyond this world	55%

Spirit-related beliefs and experiences among SBNRs. Source: Pew Research Center, 2023.

Loss, Grief, and the Persistence of Contact

The numbers on contact with the dead are not evenly distributed. Pew found that 53 percent of U.S. adults say they have ever been visited by a dead family member in a dream or some other form, and 44 percent report at least one form of interaction in the past year. These experiences are more common among women and among people who are moderately religious than among either the highly religious or the fully non-religious.

Research on after-death communication experiences shows they are frequent in the period following significant bereavement, are usually described as comforting, and are associated with a subsequent rise in belief that something continues. One multi-language study found that belief in life after death rose from roughly 69 percent to 93 percent among those who reported such an experience. The practical implication is that a reader who has lost someone close is more likely both to have reported contact and to sit higher on measures of openness to continued existence than a reader who has not. The stance that ancestors have no capacity to affect the living world remains available; it is simply less common among those who have recently navigated major loss.

From Parlor Séances to Psychic Fiction

The cultural packaging of these ideas has changed more than the underlying experiences. Victorian Spiritualism, which peaked between the 1850s and the early twentieth century, offered public, empirical-style demonstrations of contact with the dead at a moment of high mortality and theological uncertainty. Séances were social events; mediums were public figures. Fraud exposures and institutional skepticism reduced the mass social practice of physical mediumship by the mid-twentieth century.

What did not decline in parallel was the rate of reported personal contact or the belief that some non-material continuation is possible. Gallup and Pew measures of ghost belief and communication with the dead have remained in the 30–50 percent range for decades, even as formal religious affiliation fell. The dominant cultural containers shifted: private experiences, New Age practices from the 1970s onward, and, later, fictional treatments in which psychic or telepathic capacities appear as natural (if extreme) phenomena rather than as evidence of an afterlife. Cronenberg's *Scanners* and the psykers of Warhammer 40,000 are examples of the latter. The themes remain; the institutional and ritual scaffolding does not.

Where the Reader Sits

If the opening description felt like a reasonable account of your own position, the 22 percent SBNR figure is the nearest available headcount. Within that group, the afterlife numbers show high acceptance of a soul, selective acceptance of traditional destinations, and elevated openness to reincarnation. The spirit numbers show majority belief in non-corporeal forces and a strong preference for locating those forces in nature and animals rather than exclusively in a personal deity. The experiential numbers show that nearly half have felt contact from the dead, and that figure is higher still among those who have experienced significant loss.

None of this requires membership. The category exists because large numbers of people arrived at roughly the same set of refusals and openings without coordinating. The statistics do not prove the beliefs. They do show that the combination is no longer unusual, and that a reader who recognizes the pattern is, by the available measures, in the company of roughly one in five adults in the United States and a comparable or larger share in many other high-income countries. The precise content of any individual stance remains unclaimed. The distribution does not.

Claudia G. Petersen writes on culture, measurement, and the things people do when no one is keeping score.